



# FLASHPOINT

POLESTAR INSIGHTS

REPORTING PERIOD: 18 MAY 2026 - 24 MAY 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This briefing covers the activism, protest and civil-unrest picture across APAC for 18 May - 24 May 2026. The cycle is being shaped by named opposition mobilisation and sectoral chamber and union action. Coverage is regional rather than single-country: the file spans South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific, with Pakistan carrying the largest single concentration.

Severity in the file leans toward the upper end of the activism and public-order band rather than the kinetic armed-conflict tail (which sits out of scope for Flashpoint), which keeps the operational read squarely on protest disruption rather than kinetic violence.

The operational read for the next 7-14 days is that the runway from announced mobilisation to street-level disruption stays short - historically 24-72 hours once a policy trigger lands. Detailed activism, civil-unrest, forecast and country sections follow.

FAST FACTS

|                                                                    |                                                                                   |                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>REPORTING PERIOD</div> <div>18 May - 24 May 2026</div>        | <div>RECORDS IN WINDOW</div> <div>34</div> <div>15 activism, 0 civil unrest</div> | <div>HIGHEST SEVERITY</div> <div>High</div> <div>Worst rating in window</div> |
| <div>TOP ISSUE TYPE</div> <div>Protest</div> <div>21 records</div> | <div>MOST AFFECTED COUNTRY</div> <div>Pakistan</div> <div>8 records</div>         | <div>LATEST INCIDENT</div> <div>23 May 2026</div>                             |

ACTIVISM AND PROTEST READ

Across 18 May - 24 May 2026 the activism picture is led by "Opposition lawmakers stage protest in National Assembly, demand medical care for Imran" and sits in the Moderate severity band on current file evidence.

The cycle is being driven by named opposition mobilisation and sectoral chamber and union action - multiple independent organising vectors that are harder for the state to contain than a single-issue wave and that historically convert into rolling road action inside 24-72 hours of an announced date.

Operationally, the pressure points to watch are city-centre commercial districts, court complexes, party headquarters, ministry quarters and the main intercity arteries. Staff movement, last-mile logistics and customer-facing footfall are the surfaces that feel the effect first; supply-chain friction from sectoral walkouts tracks one news cycle behind.

ACTIVISM RECORDS

| DATE        | ISSUE   | TITLE                                                                                           | SEVERITY |
|-------------|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 23 May 2026 | Protest | Hundreds rally in Taipei for defence spending after parliament cuts funds - Yahoo News Malaysia | LOW      |
| 23 May 2026 | Protest | PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release                                                  | HIGH     |

| DATE        | ISSUE                  | TITLE                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | SEVERITY      |
|-------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
| 22 May 2026 | Protest                | Bangladesh Labour Congress-BNC holds a protest march in front of the National Press Club in the capital on Friday, demanding justice for the brutal murder and rape of all daughters and women, including Ramisa. - The New Nation | LOW           |
| 22 May 2026 | Protest                | Rights organisations protest over brutal rape-murder of minor girl in Bangladesh - The Assam Tribune                                                                                                                               | LOW           |
| 21 May 2026 | Protest                | Pakistan : Students hold protest in Balochistan against delay in laptop distribution , internet disruption                                                                                                                         | INSIGNIFICANT |
| 20 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | Samsung faces strike after pay talks with union fall apart - Manila Bulletin                                                                                                                                                       | LOW           |
| 20 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | Chemists strike on May 20: Why Indian pharmacists are protesting e-pharmacies over rules, pricing and safety                                                                                                                       | HIGH          |
| 20 May 2026 | Protest                | Afridi, Aleema claim shots were fired at Adiala sit-in participants                                                                                                                                                                | HIGH          |
| 19 May 2026 | Protest                | TTAP, PTI announces countrywide protests on Friday against Imran's imprisonment, rising inflation                                                                                                                                  | HIGH          |
| 19 May 2026 | Protest                | Over 200 protesting metro bus employees demand salaries in Rawalpindi                                                                                                                                                              | MODERATE      |
| 18 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | (2nd LD) Court mostly grants Samsung Electronics' injunction request against union strike                                                                                                                                          | MODERATE      |
| 18 May 2026 | Protest                | Bhopal 'dowry death': Twisha Sharma's kin protests in front of MP CM's house; seeks AIIMS post-mortem   What we know                                                                                                               | MODERATE      |

## CIVIL UNREST AND PUBLIC ORDER READ

No qualifying riot, clash, crackdown, curfew or security-force operation records reached the file across 18 May - 24 May 2026. A blank civil-unrest cycle alongside activism reporting usually means the state response has stayed below the threshold of mass arrests or curfew orders - useful, but reversible inside a single news cycle if a protest crosses a policy line.

Keep tracking police statements, district-administration orders, internet-shutdown notices and any military-aid-to-civil-power references. Those move ahead of curfew impositions and visible street-level enforcement.

## CIVIL UNREST RECORDS

*No qualifying civil-unrest records in the briefing window.*

## FORECAST: NEXT 7-14 DAYS

| COUNTRY            | SIGNAL                                                              | OPERATIONAL MEANING                                                                  |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Bangladesh</b>  | Gender-violence protest                                             | Treat as leading indicator; confirm operating impact inside 24-48h.                  |
| <b>India</b>       | Chemists' strike notice over e-pharmacy rules                       | Pharmacy supply disruption 24-72h ahead; brief procurement and customer-care.        |
| <b>Pakistan</b>    | Sectoral pay protest by transport / public-sector staff (Islamabad) | Sectoral walkout risk; brief logistics and field operations on local delays.         |
| <b>South Korea</b> | Union injunction ruling - sectoral strike risk                      | Sectoral disruption pending court ruling; pre-position contingency supply.           |
| <b>India</b>       | Family-led sit-in at official premises (Delhi)                      | Localised protest at official premises; brief venue security and visitor management. |

| COUNTRY     | SIGNAL                                         | OPERATIONAL MEANING                                                        |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| South Korea | Union injunction ruling - sectoral strike risk | Sectoral disruption pending court ruling; pre-position contingency supply. |

Confirmed forward-looking items are listed in the table above and should be the first reference points for the next 7-14 days. The trajectory commentary below sits behind that scheduled calendar.

Across the next 7-14 days, Pakistan is likely to remain the leading source of activism and civil-unrest reporting on current cadence, carrying the heaviest concentration on the current file. Adjacent cities and university campuses are possible secondary flashpoints.

Activism reporting dominates the current mix, so the most likely escalation path is from announced rallies and sectoral walkouts into intermittent road closures and city-centre disruption. Risk increases if security forces respond with mass arrests, tear gas or curfew orders; risk eases if organisers stand down voluntarily or political talks open.

Cautious read: a thin cycle is not a sustained easing in these geographies. A single political event can repopulate the file inside 48 hours, so the forecast should be treated as a baseline rather than a prediction.

## REGIONAL AND COUNTRY VIEW

Across the briefing window the file spans South Asia (led by Pakistan), East Asia (led by South Korea), Southeast Asia (led by Philippines) and Pacific (led by Papua New Guinea). The cycle is genuinely regional rather than confined to any single sub-region; Pakistan carries the heaviest concentration but is not the whole story, and operators with footprint across multiple APAC capitals should treat the picture as a coordinated rather than localised one.

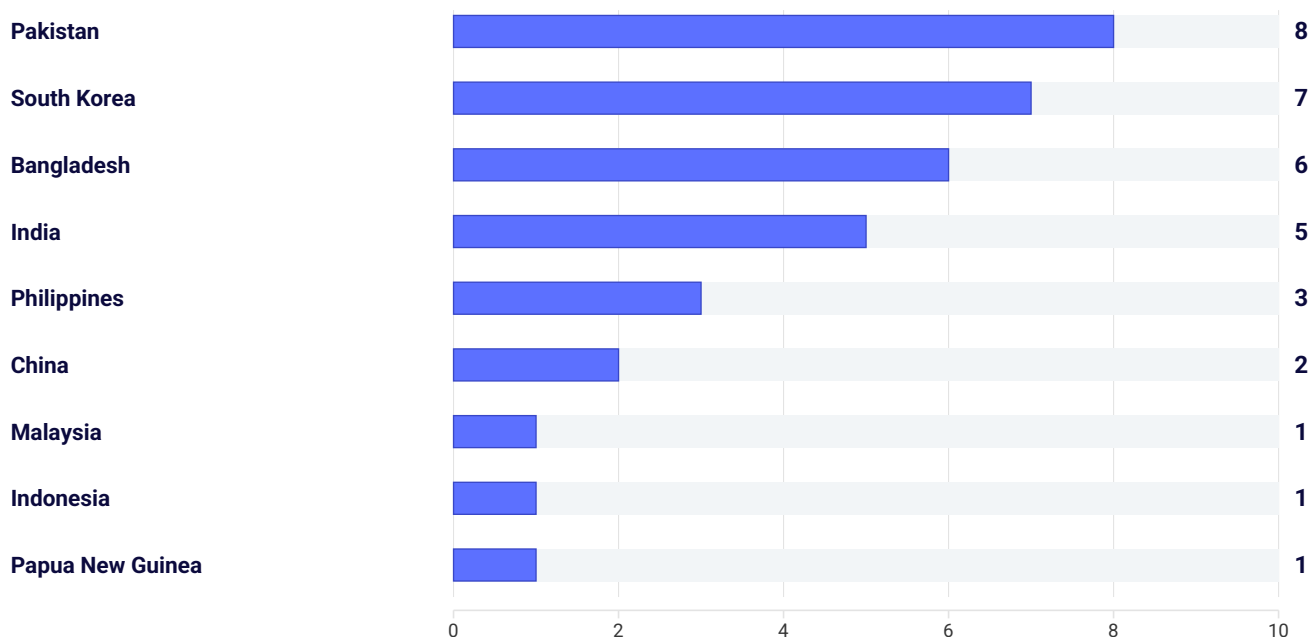
Pakistan - The lead geography this cycle, driven by protest. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, transport hubs and government precincts.

South Korea - The second-heaviest geography this cycle, driven by curfew / emergency order alongside strike / labour action. Likely form: announced rallies and sectoral walkouts that routinely draw a visible enforcement response; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, government precincts and university campuses.

Bangladesh - The third-heaviest geography this cycle, driven by protest. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, transport hubs and government precincts.

Further APAC geographies carry thinner entries this cycle and are listed in the country chart below.

## RECORDS BY COUNTRY



## WHAT MATTERS

What matters most this cycle is that the activism signal is regionally distributed across South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific rather than concentrated in a single capital. That kind of spread is harder to police, harder to forecast and routinely converts into rolling, short-notice disruption across multiple operating geographies in the same week. Pakistan sets the tempo but is not the whole picture.

The mix this cycle leans on activism rather than civil unrest, which usually means the state response has stayed below the threshold of visible enforcement. That can change inside a single news cycle if a rally crosses a policy line.

## IMPLICATIONS FOR BUSINESS

- Review staff movement plans and journey-management routings across Pakistan and the wider South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific footprint against the live protest calendar.
- Set clear work-from-home or delayed-start triggers for offices, plants and customer-facing sites in affected cities.
- Confirm alternative routes for staff, visitors and delivery movements around courts, ministries, campuses and party offices.
- Harden site access controls, perimeter checks and visitor restrictions; pre-position guard reinforcement.
- Pre-approve staff, customer and regulator communications for disruption days so messages move in minutes, not hours.
- Treat any fresh Section 144 / curfew imposition in a city of operation as an immediate WFH trigger and same-day site-closure decision.
- Wire procurement, distribution and customer-service into the security early-warning feed - sectoral chamber and union walkouts already on the file routinely run 24-72 hours ahead of supply-chain friction.

## WATCH NEXT

- Bangladesh - Gender-violence protest: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- India - Chemists' strike notice over e-pharmacy rules: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- Pakistan - Sectoral pay protest by transport / public-sector staff (Islamabad): road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.

- South Korea - Union injunction ruling - sectoral strike risk: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- India - Family-led sit-in at official premises (Delhi): road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- South Korea - Union injunction ruling - sectoral strike risk: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.

## POLESTAR VIEW

Polestar's view: the cycle reads as broadly mobilised but not yet escalatory. Multiple organising vectors are active; the state response has stayed below visible enforcement, but the gap between announced rally and hardened policing has been routinely 24-72 hours historically.

Mobilisation capacity across Pakistan is drawing on named-movement organising and sectoral chamber and union action - independent vectors with separate organising calendars, harder to contain than a single-issue wave.

Speed of escalation looks measured, but the runway is short - historically 24-72 hours from a peaceful announced rally to a kinetic incident once a political trigger lands.

Likely protest geography over the next 7-14 days: Pakistan sets the tempo and South Korea is the most likely secondary flashpoint. Expect parallel activity across South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific, clustering around court complexes, party headquarters, ministry quarters, campuses and main commercial arteries.

Business disruption risk over the next window reads as moderate-to-elevated: short-notice transport disruption on protest days, public-facing site closures driven by Section 144 / curfew orders, and supply-chain friction from sectoral walkouts. The residual tail is a triggering event - adverse court ruling, fuel-price decision, security-force fatality - flipping the cycle into sustained unrest.

## RELATED INCIDENTS

| DATE        | ISSUE                  | TITLE                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | SEVERITY |
|-------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 20 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | Chemists strike on May 20: Why Indian pharmacists are protesting e-pharmacies over rules, pricing and safety                                                                                                                       | HIGH     |
| 18 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | (2nd LD) Court mostly grants Samsung Electronics' injunction request against union strike                                                                                                                                          | MODERATE |
| 23 May 2026 | Protest                | Hundreds rally in Taipei for defence spending after parliament cuts funds - Yahoo News Malaysia                                                                                                                                    | LOW      |
| 22 May 2026 | Protest                | Bangladesh Labour Congress-BNC holds a protest march in front of the National Press Club in the capital on Friday, demanding justice for the brutal murder and rape of all daughters and women, including Ramisa. - The New Nation | LOW      |
| 20 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | Samsung faces strike after pay talks with union fall apart - Manila Bulletin                                                                                                                                                       | LOW      |
| 23 May 2026 | Protest                | PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release                                                                                                                                                                                     | HIGH     |

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